

Express + EJS: Views Directory & path.join()

Quick notes from our discussion

1. What is the views directory?

In an Express application using EJS, the **views** directory normally contains your EJS templates. These files look like HTML but can contain EJS expressions such as `<%= username %>`.

```
my-app/  
  app.js  
  package.json  
  views/  
    index.ejs  
    products.ejs  
    profile.ejs
```

2. Tell Express to use EJS

```
app.set("view engine", "ejs");
```

Meaning: **When Express renders a view, use EJS as the template engine.**

3. Tell Express where the views folder is

```
const path = require("path");  
  
app.set("views", path.join(__dirname, "views"));
```

Meaning: **Express, look for my template files inside this views directory.**

4. Why use path.join(__dirname, 'views')?

`__dirname` represents the directory containing the current JavaScript file. `path.join()` safely combines directory names into a path appropriate for the operating system.

```
__dirname  
  ↓  
C:\Users\Kush\Desktop\myapp  
  
path.join(__dirname, "views")  
  ↓  
C:\Users\Kush\Desktop\myapp\views
```

5. How res.render() finds the EJS file

```
app.get("/", (req, res) => {  
  res.render("index");  
});
```

Express uses the configured **views** directory, looks for the requested template, and uses the configured **EJS** engine to turn it into HTML.

```
res.render("index")  
  ↓
```

```
views/
  ↓
index.ejs
  ↓
EJS processes template
  ↓
HTML
  ↓
Browser
```

6. Complete example

```
const express = require("express");
const path = require("path");

const app = express();

app.set("view engine", "ejs");
app.set("views", path.join(__dirname, "views"));

app.get("/", (req, res) => {
  res.render("home");
});

app.listen(3000);
```

Project structure

```
backend/
  ■■■ app.js
  ■■■ views/
    ■■■ home.ejs
```

7. Dynamic EJS example

```
app.get("/product/:id", (req, res) => {
  const id = req.params.id;

  res.render("product", {
    productId: id
  });
});
<!-- views/product.ejs -->

<h1>Product Page</h1>
<p>Product ID: <%= productId %></p>
```

Visiting **/product/101** renders the same template with productId = 101. Visiting **/product/500** renders it with productId = 500.

8. The three key ideas to remember

Code	Purpose
app.set("view engine", "ejs")	Use EJS for templates
app.set("views", path.join(__dirname, "views"))	Tell Express where templates are

res.render("home")	Render home.ejs from the views directory
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Memory trick: View engine = *WHAT* renders the page. Views path = *WHERE* the templates live. res.render() = *WHICH* template to render.